

Questions Matter

Every conversation with AI starts the same way: you ask it something. That small moment decides more about what you get back than anything else you do.

Strip it down and there are only two parts: the question and the answer. For decades, technology has been making answers easier and easier to get. And the less time we spend chasing the answer, the more time we have for the half that’s still ours: **asking the right question**.

One example makes the whole idea click. Teachers have been handing out research assignments since the dawn of school. But look at what happened to the process between your grandparents, your parents, and you.

How answers got cheap

PRE-INTERNET (GRANDPARENTS) The library	THE INTERNET (PARENTS) Search	NOW (YOU) AI
1. Get to a library and search the card catalog 2. Track down the right books and periodicals on the shelves 3. Read until you find what you need, copying notes by hand	1. Run search after search, opening tab after tab 2. Judge which sites to trust and skim for the useful parts 3. Copy and paste the good pieces into a doc	1. Open your favorite AI app 2. Ask 3. The answer is on your screen
TIME TO ANSWER Half a Saturday	TIME TO ANSWER An hour or two	TIME TO ANSWER Seconds

Half a day, then an hour, now seconds. AI makes answers cheap. That does not make humans less valuable. It changes *where* value lives.

For your grandparents, knowing how to hunt down an answer was a real skill. AI just did the hunting in seconds, but it only answered the question it was given. When anyone can get a fast answer, the edge shifts to the person who can ask the better question.

WHAT MAKES A GOOD QUESTION?

Asking good questions is not an AI skill. It’s one of the oldest skills there is. Socrates taught by doing almost nothing but asking. The scientific method doesn’t start with an answer; it starts with a question worth testing. Einstein supposedly said that with an hour to save the world, he’d spend the first 55 minutes finding the right question.

So what separates a good question from a weak one? Four qualities, and none of them mention AI.

1

Open-Minded

You haven’t picked the answer in advance. A leading question isn’t research, it’s a request for backup.

BAD

Give me proof that homework doesn’t help students learn.

BETTER

What does the research actually say about homework and learning?

2

Specific

It names your situation, not just the topic. A question you could ask about anything returns an answer that helps with nothing.

BAD

How do I get better at basketball?

BETTER

I’m a point guard who loses the ball against pressure. What drills fix that?

3

On Target

Ask about the thing you’re actually trying to figure out, not a piece on the edge of it. The wrong target gets a perfect answer to the wrong question.

BAD

How do I make my slides look better?

BETTER

My presentation isn’t landing. Help me figure out whether the problem is my slides or the order of my points.

4

Open-Ended

A yes-or-no question ends the conversation; an open-ended one starts it. Leave room for an answer you didn’t expect.

BAD

Should I join the debate team?

BETTER

What would joining debate add to my week, and what would I have to give up for it?

Notice that AI hasn’t come up yet. These four qualities worked in Socrates’ Athens and they work in a chat window. What changed is the payoff: now that answers are instant, the quality of the question is the whole game.

A better question doesn’t make the answer automatically true. It just makes the answer more focused, more useful, and easier to check.

The advantage no longer goes to whoever produces the fastest first answer. It goes to the person who frames the problem, sets the standard, and asks the next better question.